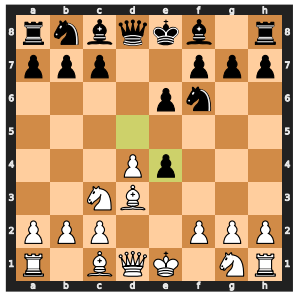
Game 12



French Defence

Capablanca – Chajes

New York, 1918

White: J. R. Capablanca Black: O. Chajes

Notes by J. R. Capablanca, from Chess Fundamentals *(1921), which is in the public domain.*
Descriptive notation has been converted to algebraic. Page references are to the book.
Click any move or diagram to open it on Lichess.

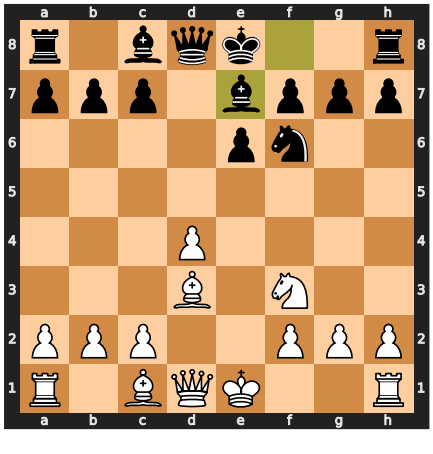
1.e4 e6 2.d4 d5 3.♘c3 ♘f6 4.♗d3

Not the most favoured move, but a perfectly natural developing one, and consequently it cannot be bad.

4...dxe4

4...c5 is generally played in this case instead of the text move.

5.♘xe4 ♘bd7 6.♘xf6+ ♘xf6 7.♘f3 ♗e7



8.♕e2

This is played to prevent ...b6, followed by ♗b7, which is the general form of development for Black in this variation. If Black now plays 8...b6 9.♗b5+ ♗d7 10.♘e5 and White obtains a considerable advantage in position.

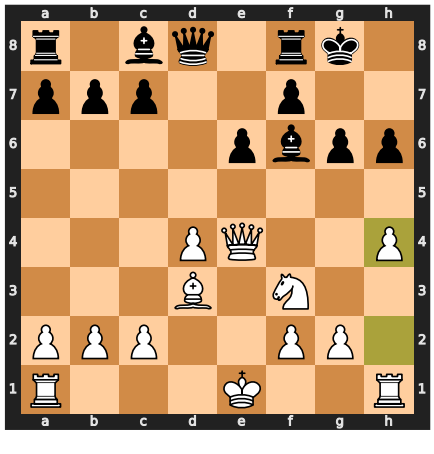
8...0–0 9.♗g5 h6

Of course Black could not play 9...b6 because of 10.♗xf6, followed by ♕e4.

10.♗xf6 ♗xf6 11.♕e4 g6

This weakens Black's King's side. 11... ♖e8 was the right move.

12.h4



12...e5

This is merely giving up a Pawn in order to come out quickly with his Queen's Bishop. But

as he does not obtain any compensation for his Pawn, the move is bad. He should have played 12...♕d5 and tried to fight the game out that way. It might have continued thus: 13.♕f4 ♗g7 14.♕xc7 ♗xd4 15.♘xd4 ♕xd4 16.0–0–0 with considerable advantage of position for White. The text move might be considered a mild form of suicide.

13.dxe5 ♗f5 14.♕f4 ♗xd3 15.0–0–0 ♗g7 16.♖xd3 ♕e7 17.♕c4

In order to keep the Black Queen from coming into the game.

17...♖ad8 18.♖hd1

A better plan would have been to play 18.♖e1, threatening e6.

18...♖xd3 19.♖xd3 ♖e8 20.c3 c6

Of course if 20...♗xe5 21.♘xe5 ♕xe5 22.♖e3. Black with a Pawn minus fights very hard.

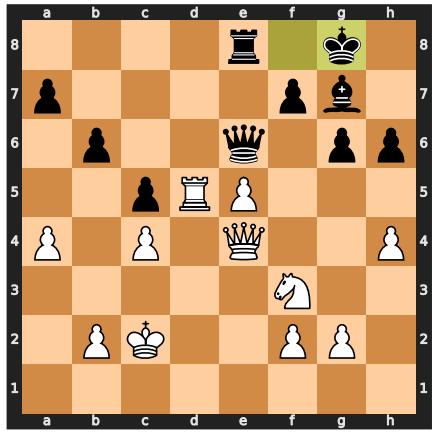
21.♖e3

The Pawn had now to be defended after Black's last move, because after ♗xe5; ♘xe5, ♕xe5; ♖e3, Black could now play ♕b8 defending the Rook.

21...c5 22.♔c2 b6 23.a4

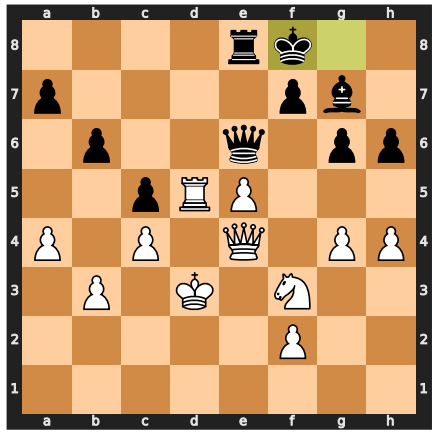
White's plan now is to *fix* the Queen's side in order to be able to manoeuvre freely on the other side, where he has the advantage of material.

23...♕d7 24.♖d3 ♕c8 25.♕e4 ♕e6 26.♖d5 ♔f8 27.c4 ♔g8



Black sees that he now stands in his best defensive position, and therefore waits for White to show how he intends to break through. He notices, of course, that the White Knight is in the way of the f-pawn, which cannot advance to f4 to defend, or support rather, the Pawn at e5.

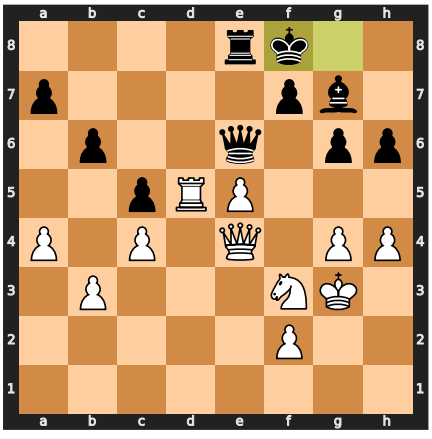
28.b3 ♔f8 29.♔d3 ♔g8 30.♖d6 ♕c8 31.♖d5 ♕e6 32.g4 ♔f8 33.♕f4 ♔g8 34.♕e4 ♔f8



Black persists in waiting for developments. He sees that if 35.h5 gxh5 36.gxh5, the Queen goes to h3, and White will have to face serious difficulties. In this situation White decides that the only course is to bring his King to g3, so as to defend the squares h3 and g4, where the Black Queen might otherwise become a source of annoyance.

35.♔e2 ♔g8 36.♔f1 ♔f8 37.♔g2 ♔g8 38.♔g3 ♔f8

Now that he has completed his march with the King, White is ready to advance.



39.h5 gxh5

39...g5 would be answered by 40.♕f5, with a winning game.

40.gxh5 ♕e7

Against 40...♔g8; White would play 41.♕g4, practically forcing the exchange of Queens, after which White would have little trouble in winning the ending, since Black's Bishop could not do much damage in the resulting position.

41.♕f5 ♔g8

Black overlooks the force of 42.♖d7. His best defence was 41...♖d8; against which White could either advance the King or play ♘h4, threatening ♘g6+.

42.♖d7 ♗xe5+

This loses a piece, but Black's position was altogether hopeless.

43.♔g4 ♕f6 44.♘xe5 ♕g7+ 45.♔f4 Resigns.

The interest of this game centres mainly on the opening and on the march of the White King during the final stage of the game. It is an instance of the King becoming a fighting piece, even while the Queens are still on the board.